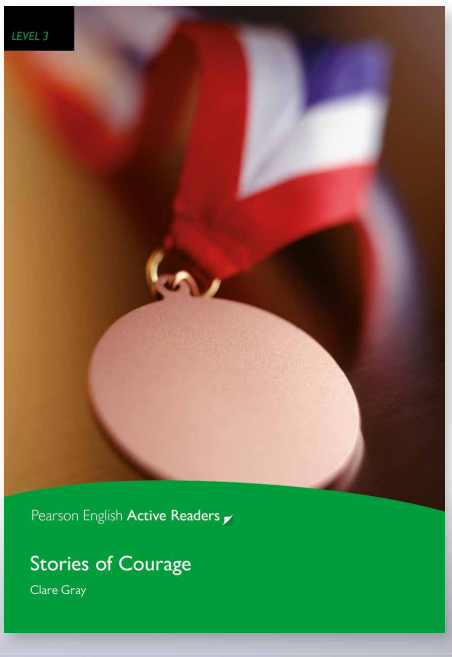
STORIES OF COURAGE by Clare Gray (A2+–B1)



PREPARATION

1 **Look at the photos and answer the questions.**

see

1 Who can you see?
2 What are they doing?

think

3 How do you think they feel?

wonder

4 What might be difficult if you had to live in another country?



The River to Freedom

1 .....

Six months earlier, Matthew was sitting outside his family home in the south of Sudan with his father. Suddenly, soldiers interrupted their peaceful evening. "We didn't say anything," he remembers. "We waited for a question ... but there was no question ... They just shot my father."

2 .....

Matthew was taken to an army prison – one more prisoner in Sudan's long war. His room was too small for a bed and too low to stand up in. His only visitors were the soldiers, who came every day to beat the prisoners.

One day, the prison guards decided to move some of the prisoners. Matthew stepped painfully into the bright sun and looked at the outside world for the first time in six months. He noticed a dirty grey stream running from the prison buildings, through the yard, and under the prison wall.

3 .....

"I asked a guard where the water went," Matthew remembers. When he learned it ran into the Nile, Matthew felt hope. "Don't even think about it," said a guard, pointing at the powerful electricity lines that crossed the water near the prison walls. "If you touch those lines, you're dead!"

Escape seemed hopeless, but he looked at the other broken men around him and he knew that he had to try.

4 .....

As the line of prisoners walked across the yard, Matthew stayed near the back. Then he suddenly turned away from the other prisoners and jumped into the grey water. The water carried his weak body under the electricity lines, and from one type of danger to another. For days he floated without sleep or food. But as his courage carried him north, it also carried him away from his painful past.

He left the river and started walking east to Port Sudan. For three and a half months he travelled overland, keeping away from people and towns in case the soldiers found him. He felt hungry and lonely but he bravely fought his fears and feelings.

5 .....

Tired and weak, Matthew arrived in busy Port Sudan, found a ship and said goodbye to his country. It was a brave step toward an unknown future. Today Matthew (not his real name) lives happily in Sofia, Bulgaria. His new friends know him as a big, tall man, but his true strength is much greater than the eye can see.

GLOSSARY

courage *n.* the ability to do something even though you are afraid
overland *adv.* by land, not by water

LISTENING

2 LL6.01 **Listen to the beginning of a true story about an African man called Matthew. Why was he lucky this time?**

GLOSSARY

shiver *v.* when your body makes small, fast movements if you are cold or afraid

ache *v.* feel pain

READING

3 LL6.02 **Now listen and read the rest of Matthew's story.**

COMPREHENSION

4 **Match the headings a)–g) with the paragraphs 1–5. There are two headings that you do not need.**

a) A chance for freedom
b) Army life
c) The escape
d) A new life
e) Help arrives
f) The last day of normal life
g) A hard life

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

5 **Life in Sudan was dangerous for Matthew so he escaped to Bulgaria as a refugee. Find out more about refugees today.**

1 How many refugees came to your country this year?
2 Which countries did they come from?
3 What are some of the reasons they had to leave their countries?

SPEAKING

6 **Work in small groups. Find out about a famous or successful refugee, in your country or another country. Tell your partner about the person.**

1 Who are they?
2 Where did they come from and why did they leave?
3 Which country did they make their new home in?
4 How did they become successful?

CLIL CONNECTION

Citizenship

7 **Think about the rights and responsibilities that citizens have.**

Rights: things your country and government make possible for you

Responsibilities: things you do for your country

1 Look at the words in the box and underline any new words. Check their meaning in a dictionary.

worship according to your religion
respect the law pay taxes
be equal to other citizens vote
have a fair trial in court
have an education
express your opinions
carry identification

2 Decide which things are rights and which are responsibilities. Some may be both.
3 Which responsibility do you think is the most important? Why?

